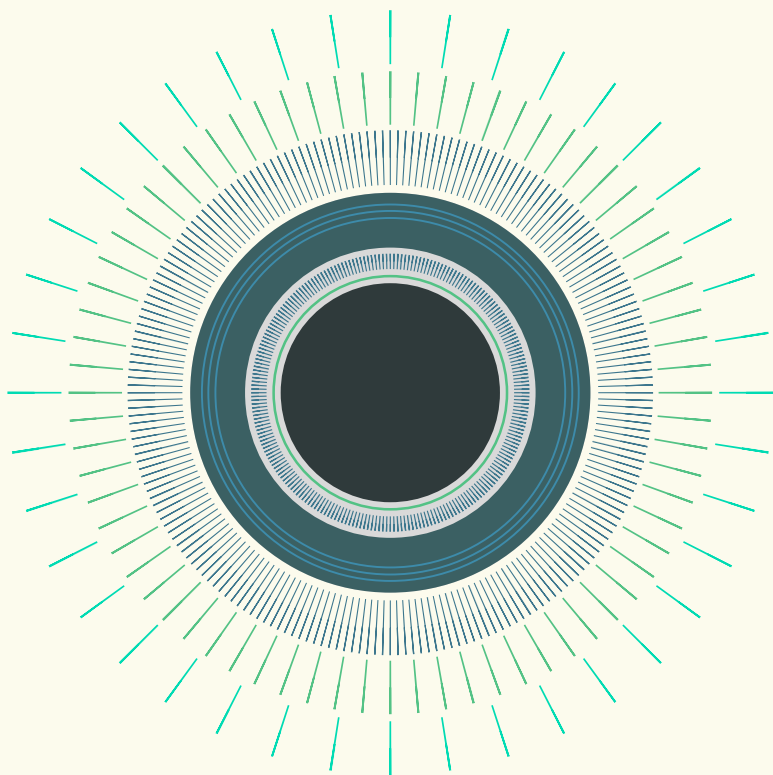




AUDITION TAPE

a monologue by
Josh Worth

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A monologue

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Audition Tape #179:

Maxine McDougall

Maxine looks into the lens of the camera. She adjusts the angle slightly so that she is centered in the frame, then takes a seat about six feet away.

MAXINE

My name's Maxine McDonald. I'm 27. From Los Angeles.

And I would love to appear as a contestant (contestant, participant... guinea pig, whatever) — on *The Chosen One*. I'd be great. I'm just who you're looking for. I'm funny and carefree. Your viewers will love me.

Why will they love me? Well, for one, I'm not like those other girls you get on there. With the squeaky voices and the bad hair...

And that *tone* that seems so heartfelt and revealing? But really it leads to nothing? You know what I'm talking about, right? I'm sure. You guys are smart. It's a great idea for a show... You've got to be smart.(?)

Vapid. That's the word. I can't believe that's what you're looking for. Is it?... Those bitches? Or is that what happens? They all start off interesting, with some real thoughts — but once you're done with them — with the

editing and all that – they’re all... hollowed out. I hope not.

I like to think that the camera sees some kind of truth in people... Like it’s magic. I saw on some show about how TVs actually work. Did you know it’s the same principal as the northern lights? The *Aurora Borealis*? It’s accelerated electrons colliding with gases. In the sky it’s the solar wind hitting the atmosphere. In a TV it’s a cathode ray hitting a screen covered in phosphor.

Did you know that? Probably not. You only worry about what’s *on* a TV not what’s in it. I guess that’s okay. I’ve never seen the Northern lights either. But I’m sure it’s pretty amazing. Like a big glowy TV show. (Or something)

I’m kind of TV-crazy. I watch too much. Always have. I don’t think my parents paid enough attention to me. They’re busy people. Busy being busy.

I had to work my ass off to get their attention as a kid. Dancing. Singing. Trying to be cute. Screaming. They didn’t care. I put on plays in the basement about how I died and nobody came to my funeral... They sent me to a therapist after that. He said I had “attention deficit disorder.” No shit. Nobody *paid* me any attention so I

had a deficit. Why do they talk about attention like it's money? It's so stupid.

But I'm off the Ritalin, so that's good. Just Prozac for me now.

She gives a vacant, robotic smile.

I tried to be an actress a while back, but it's all such bullshit. There are so many people trying to do it that you're just like this little speck of nothing. It's so degrading.

My acting teacher said, "You just gotta put yourself out there. Just do your own thing and hope that someone notices you." So I've been doing that. I was in some student films that no one saw and a few plays that no one came to. Then I started keeping a blog on the internet. I was getting like four hits a day. I thought that was pretty cool - "Hey! Four people care about what I think!" - then I found out that every time I updated my page it counted as a hit, and then every time I went to check the counter it counted as another... And I'm pretty sure my ex-boyfriend was reading it to see if I would say anything about him. That left me with one lurking stranger.

It's like, nowadays, everyone's so busy putting on their own little show that, you're lucky if you can even get yourself as an audience. You guys don't have that problem though. You've got like, millions of viewers, right? You're

part of the big show. We're all just hovering around like a bunch of moths.

So let's see...

She reads from the application form.

"What is it that makes me original?" – probably the same stuff that makes everyone original, right? That's a joke. No – I don't know. Do you mean like, do I have some mental condition where I'll punch somebody in the face if someone steals a pickle from me? Yeah. Probably. I believe in fighting for what's mine. For what I want. Not that I've been in too many fights. Just a couple when I was drunk.

I have a cool scar, though.

She pulls her hair away from her forehead and leans into the camera.

Maybe you can't see it. It wasn't from a fight though. Actually, maybe that's something that makes me special... I've been dead before. It was only forty-five seconds, but they tell me I was definitely dead.

It happened when I was just out of college. I was over at my friend Jackie's apartment in Venice Beach drinking vodka and stuff. She had just gotten a new roommate – this guy named Robert who was really cool and interesting and kind of crazy. So I was over there trying to do things to get him to notice me, but he was with a

bunch of guys from his band watching a re-run from the Lawrence Welk Show and talking about how they wanted to copy this skit for their music video. And even though I kept making jokes and being cute, he wouldn't even look at me. I couldn't tell what his deal was, if he was just shy or he wasn't into me, or what.

Anyway, the show ended, and we're all sitting in the living room on this giant yellow couch when the ten o'clock news comes on. It was a story about this Cher impersonator who kidnapped a little girl to try and get Cher's attention. The last place they were spotted was at Windward and Pacific in Venice Beach. And they were reporting live from right there – just across the street from Jackie's apartment. I knew just where the reporter was standing because I could see the arches by the liquor store and the posters on the wall next to Anjelica Huston's house. So I was like "Hey! Watch for me!"

So I go running out the door and across the street and I can see the news van on the street and the reporter lady standing right there on the sidewalk with a bright light shining on her from the camera.

So I walk around behind her and pretend to look at the posters. It was totally obvious I was trying to get on camera, but I played it all cool and nonchalant. The reporter was just standing there waiting – they had cut away to a pre-recorded segment or something, but then I hear the cameraman say "We're back in 3-2." And the

reporter closes the story with “This is so and so reporting live from Venice Beach.” And in the distance, across the street, I can hear Jackie and everyone cheering for me from the apartment. So I’m beaming with victory, and I go running back across the street to receive my accolades. But I’m so excited that I don’t even see that a motorcycle is speeding right at me. It skids out and hits me and I go flying into the windshield of a parked car.

I blacked out at that point. I don’t remember much. Some paramedics trying to talk to me. The sirens. The movement of the ambulance. Apparently I had some internal bleeding which the doctors didn’t notice at first. At some point, at the hospital, I remember hearing someone say “We’re losing her.” Which is when I floated away.

It was really weird. It was like I was looking down from the ceiling at the doctors crowded around my body on the operating table. I was scared at first. I knew something was very wrong and just wanted to get back in my body. But then, all of a sudden, I felt this powerful force pulling me through, like a black tunnel, at an incredible speed and I could hear this buzzing wind in my ears.

Then I saw that light that everyone talks about. It was the most beautiful thing I’d ever seen. I felt really warm and happy. It was a feeling of *belonging*, of being welcome. Like I was being invited to the greatest party in the history of the universe and it was being thrown in my honor. I was moving slowly into the light – it was spinning and pulsing – and I started to see shapes moving

around inside of it – like a crowd of people cheering for me.

The next thing I knew, though, I was feeling shocks on my chest and I was back in my body in the hospital. I was kind of pissed actually. I didn't like that feeling – like one second I'm this enormous, free-floating thing, and the next I'm being shrunk down and shoved into this tiny body. I still get that feeling sometimes.

But I'm glad it happened, actually. It's kind of nice to know I've had a break. It's like... your heart and lungs are going constantly from the second you're born. No matter what, they're inside of you pumping and pulsing. It's relentless, when you think about it. It was a relief to just be still inside, at least once in my life.

It definitely made me happier to be here. But maybe also a little more desperate too. I don't know... That light that I saw when I was dead... it reminded me of the light on the camera that was pointed at the newswoman. It made me think that the light at the end, it isn't just this beacon to guide you on. It's a light that shines so the ones on the other side can get a good clear picture of you. So they can decide if they like what they see.

Anyway. How many other girls do you get who've died and lived to tell about it? Not too many, I bet.

I've tried to get on TV like a hundred times since the accident. I can't even tell you how many times I've made

a tape like this and just tossed it out into the hands of people like you. So I won't be surprised if you toss it right back. I've given up on any dreams of super-stardom at this point. I'm realistic. I don't practice my Oscar speech in the mirror or anything. But I'd just like the chance to be seen, you know? Before I die again. I just think it would be good for me to know that I've left some kind of imprint on people's minds, even if it's just for half-an-hour.

You guys should know though – not that it'll make any difference – but this is your last shot, your last chance to put Maxine McDougall in the big show. So don't blow it... After this, I'm not even trying anymore. I'll just go hide out somewhere and wallow in eternal obscurity. Maybe I'll go to Canada. You can see the Northern lights from up there, can't you? That would be nice.

She walks up to the camera and turns it off.